A SERMON FOR THE PULPIT

The Woman Who Ended the War

A sermon on Jael

THE BIG IDEA

Jael drove a tent peg through the enemy's head and was called blessed; Jesus let the nails be driven into his hands and made peace for his enemies.

PRIMARY TEXT	Judges 4:1–24
ALSO READ	Judges 5; Luke 1:26–45; Colossians 2:13–15; 1 Corinthians 1:26–31
TIME	50–60 minutes, including a 3–5 minute response.

Scripture quotations are ESV. Swap to your pulpit translation freely.

A COMPLETE MANUSCRIPT FOR THE PULPIT

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Introduction: The story we skip

There is a story in the book of Judges that almost never makes it into the children's Bible. Deborah makes it. Barak makes it. The chariots and the river make it, usually as a flannelgraph with a lot of blue felt. But the tent peg does not make it. The hammer does not make it. Jael does not make it.

We can understand why. A woman invites a fleeing general into her tent, gives him milk, covers him with a rug, promises to guard the door, and then, while he sleeps, drives a tent peg through his head. It is not a story you tell with puppets. It is violent, strange, and morally uncomfortable. The man is a fugitive. He trusts her. She kills him.

And yet Deborah's song calls her "most blessed of women" (Judges 5:24). Not tolerated. Not excused. Blessed. The Bible does not whisper this story. It sings it.

We are used to Bible stories that have been cleaned up for us. Noah's ark becomes a nursery mural. David and Goliath becomes a lesson about believing in yourself. The cross becomes a piece of jewelry. We sand down the edges until the Bible sounds like us. But this story will not sand down. It puts a hammer in a woman's hand and a peg through a man's head, and then it calls her blessed. If we are going to hear what God is saying, we have to let the story be as strange as it is.

That means we cannot skip it. If the Spirit of God chose to preserve this story and put a blessing on this woman's head, then there is something here we need. This is not a story about how to be nice. It is a story about how God wins. It is a story about a war that would not end, a general who ran, a woman nobody expected, and a deliverance that came through a household tool.

Here is the big idea: Jael drove a tent peg through the enemy's head and was called blessed; Jesus let the nails be driven into his hands and made peace for his enemies.

That is where we are going. We will watch God win a battle Israel could not win. We will sit in the tent with a man who thinks he is safe. We will feel the weight of the hammer. And we will see, in the strange mercy of God, a picture of the greater deliverance that was still to come.

Let us read the story.

Movement 1: The twenty-year silence

Judges 4 begins the way so many of these stories begin. "And the people of Israel again did what was evil in the LORD's sight" (4:1). The cycle is familiar: sin, oppression, crying out, deliverance, and then the slow drift back into the same old patterns. This time the oppression has a name and a machine.

"And the LORD sold them into the hand of Jabin king of Canaan, who reigned in Hazor. The commander of his army was Sisera, who lived in Harosheth-hagoyim. Then the people of Israel cried out to the LORD for help, for he had 900 chariots of iron and he oppressed the people of Israel cruelly for twenty years" (4:2–3).

Twenty years. We need to feel the weight of that number. This is not a raid. It is a generation. Children were born into this. Farmers learned which roads to avoid. Families learned to live with the sound of chariots in the valley. The enemy did not need to occupy every village; he only needed to make sure no one could stand up.

And the chariots were not a metaphor. In the ancient world, a chariot was the tank, the cavalry, and the psychological weapon all at once. Nine hundred of them, made of iron, in a valley where Israel had no answer. Israel was a hill-country people with slings and spears and courage. Sisera had the technology, the training, and the flat ground. The math was not close.

But the deepest problem was not the chariots. It was the reason they were there. The LORD had sold His people into the hand of the enemy. This was not a random tragedy. It was covenant discipline. They had traded the worship of the living God for the gods of the land, and the gods of the land had handed them over to a king with iron wheels. The oppression was a message: the thing you chose is now ruling you.

Still, they cried out. That is grace. God does not wait for His people to clean themselves up before He hears them. He hears the cry of a people who have nothing to offer but their need. And He raises a deliverer.

Her name is Deborah. She is a prophetess, the wife of Lappidoth, and she is judging Israel at that time (4:4). She holds court under the palm of Deborah, between Ramah and Bethel, and the people come up to her for judgment. A woman, in a society that did not expect a woman to lead, is the mouthpiece of God and the mother of Israel. The song she sings later says it plainly: "The villagers ceased in Israel; they ceased to be until I arose, I, Deborah, arose as a mother in Israel" (5:7).

Do not rush past that. God did not need a man to lead His people. He chose a woman, and He gave her His word. That is not a footnote; it is part of the story's offense and its glory. God's deliverance does not fit our categories.

Deborah summons Barak, the son of Abinoam from Kedesh in Naphtali, and gives him a word from the LORD: "Has not the LORD, the God of Israel, commanded you, 'Go, gather your men at Mount Tabor, taking 10,000 from the people of Naphtali and the people of Zebulun. And I will draw out Sisera, the general of Jabin's army, to meet you by the river Kishon with his chariots and his troops, and I will give him into your hand'?" (4:6–7).

Notice the promise. God will draw Sisera out. God will give him into Barak's hand. The battle is already decided before a single soldier musters. The only question is whether Barak will go.

And Barak says, "If you will go with me, I will go, but if you will not go with me, I will not go" (4:8).

Is that faith or fear? The honest answer is both. Hebrews 11:32 names Barak among the faithful. He believed enough to go. But he did not believe enough to go without the prophet. He wanted a visible sign of God's presence. He wanted Deborah in the chariot, so to speak. He is not a villain. He is one of us on a Monday morning, believing the promise and still wanting someone to hold his hand.

Deborah agrees. But she adds a word that changes the shape of the story: "I will surely go with you. Nevertheless, the road on which you are going will not lead to your glory, for the LORD will sell Sisera into the hand of a woman" (4:9).

Which woman? That is the question the rest of the chapter answers. Deborah is a woman. Perhaps she means herself. Perhaps she means some unnamed woman in the camp. The reader is left to wait.

The general will win the battle, but he will not get the final honor. The honor will go to a woman. God is already reversing the order. The strong man with the army will not be the one who ends the war.

Movement 2: The battle at Kishon

Barak gathers 10,000 men from Naphtali and Zebulun and goes up to Mount Tabor. Sisera gathers all his chariots, 900 of them, and all his troops, and comes to the river Kishon (4:10–13). The valley below Tabor is the perfect ground for chariots. It is the worst possible ground for an

infantry army with no armor. From a human point of view, Barak is leading 10,000 men into a meat grinder.

Deborah speaks the battle cry: "Up! For this is the day in which the LORD has given Sisera into your hand. Does not the LORD go out before you?" (4:14).

That is the whole theology of the battle in one sentence. The LORD goes out before them. They are not walking into a fair fight. They are walking into a victory that has already been promised.

Barak goes down from Tabor with 10,000 men behind him. And the text says, "And the LORD routed Sisera and all his chariots and all his army before Barak by the edge of the sword. And Sisera got down from his chariot and fled away on foot" (4:15).

The LORD routed him. Not Barak. Not the 10,000. The LORD. The soldiers fought, the swords were drawn, and the valley became the place where God kept His word.

And the rout was total. "And Barak pursued the chariots and the army to Harosheth-hagoyim, and all the army of Sisera fell by the edge of the sword; not a man was left" (4:16). Not a man was left. The army that had ruled the valley for twenty years ceased to exist in a single afternoon. The iron chariots that had been the terror of Israel were abandoned on the field. The soldiers who had come out to crush a rebellion were not sent home; they were buried where they fell.

This is the God of the Bible. He is not a distant deity who watches history from a safe distance. He is the LORD of hosts, the God of armies, the one who goes out before His people. He does not fight fair, and He does not need to. He made the stars, the river, the ground, and the iron. When He goes to war, the whole creation is His army.

The Song of Deborah gives us the unseen side of the battle: "From heaven the stars fought, from their courses they fought against Sisera. The torrent Kishon swept them away, the ancient torrent, the torrent Kishon" (5:20–21).

The stars fought. The river swept them away. The chariots that were supposed to be invincible became the trap. The ground that was supposed to give Sisera the advantage became the place where the flood took him. The LORD of the armies of heaven and the LORD of the river is the same LORD. Creation itself joins the battle when God goes to war.

And the mighty general does what mighty generals do when the battle turns: he runs. He leaves his chariot and flees on foot. The man with 900 iron chariots is now a man with two feet and a head start. The narrative is already stripping him of his glory. In the ancient world, a general

who abandoned his chariot and ran from a woman's tent would have been a joke. But nobody is laughing. The man is running for his life.

Sisera runs to the tent of Jael, the wife of Heber the Kenite. The text gives us the reason: "For there was peace between Jabin the king of Hazor and the house of Heber the Kenite" (4:17). He is not running to an Israelite. He is running to a neutral party, a family with a treaty with his king. He thinks he is running to safety. He is running to the one place in the valley where the war will end.

Who are the Kenites? They are descendants of Hobab, Moses' father-in-law, a people who had thrown in their lot with Israel generations earlier (Judges 1:16; 4:11). But Heber has separated from the main group and pitched his tent by Kedesh. He has made his own peace with Jabin. His wife Jael is not an Israelite. She has no covenant obligation to Israel, no debt to Barak, no reason to risk her life for the God of the Hebrews.

From a human point of view, she is the wrong person to carry the hope of Israel. She is a woman, a foreigner, and the wife of a man who has made peace with the enemy. And that is exactly why God chose her.

The battle is over, but the enemy is still alive. The victory is not complete until Sisera is dead. The word through Deborah said the honor would go to a woman. The camera leaves the battlefield and follows a fleeing man to a tent door.

Movement 3: The open door

Jael comes out to meet Sisera. She does not run from him; she walks toward him. And she says, "Turn aside, my lord; turn aside to me; do not be afraid" (4:18).

Her words are careful. She calls him "my lord." She offers hospitality. She tells him not to be afraid. Everything about her posture says: you are safe here. The man who has been running from a routed army hears the most welcome words in the world.

"So he turned aside to her into the tent, and she covered him with a rug" (4:18).

The tent is a woman's space in this culture. A man entering a woman's tent and lying down under her care is a picture of vulnerability, even if he does not know it. He is exhausted. He is humiliated. He has lost his chariot, his army, and his reputation in a single afternoon. He is not thinking about danger. He is thinking about sleep.

Then he asks for water. "Please give me a little water to drink, for I am thirsty" (4:19). She opens a skin of milk, gives him a drink, and covers him with the rug. The song adds the detail: "He asked for water; she gave him milk; in a lordly bowl she brought him curds" (5:25). She does not give him the minimum. She gives him a feast. She treats him like an honored guest.

In the ancient world, hospitality was sacred. A guest under your roof was under your protection. You were responsible for his life. You would defend him against his enemies. To betray a guest was a profound violation of honor. Jael knows this. She is not ignorant of the rules. She is about to break every one of them.

Sisera gives her his next instruction: "Stand at the door of the tent, and if any man comes and asks you, 'Is anyone here?' say, 'No'" (4:20). He asks her to guard the door and to lie for him. He is turning his protector into an accomplice. He is putting his life in her hands without knowing whose hands they are.

She agrees. Or at least she does not argue. The text moves quickly. He lies down. He sleeps. And the camera stays in the tent.

This is the point where we have to be honest about the story. Jael is not a passive bystander. She is not a symbol. She is a woman who makes a decision in the middle of a war. She could have hidden Sisera, sent him away, or waited for Barak to arrive. She chooses the tent peg.

Why? The text does not tell us. Perhaps she sees that the tide has turned. Perhaps she believes the God of Israel has won. Perhaps she is afraid of what will happen if Sisera is found in her tent. Perhaps she is honoring the God of her ancestors. We do not know. What we know is that she acts. She does not wait for permission. She does not wait for a better moment. She takes the tool that is in her hand and she uses it.

There is a deeper question here, and we should not dodge it: is this right? Jael deceives a man who trusts her and kills him in his sleep. She violates hospitality and her household's treaty with Jabin. In any ordinary moral framework, this is a betrayal.

But this is not an ordinary story. This is a war of deliverance, and Sisera is not a private guest. He is the commander of an army that has oppressed God's people for twenty years. He is a man under the judgment of God. Deborah's song does not treat Jael as a murderer; it calls her "most blessed of women." The Bible is not endorsing every act of deception or every act of violence. It is telling us what God did in this moment, through this woman, to break the back of the enemy.

We should feel the weight of that. The Bible is not squeamish, and it is not sentimental. It does not pretend that deliverance is clean. Jael's hands will be stained. The tent will have blood in it.

The story of salvation is a story of judgment before it is a story of peace. If we cannot bear that, we will not understand the cross, where the judgment of God fell on His own Son.

Still, we must be careful how we preach this. Jael is not a model for personal revenge. She is not a permission slip for vigilante violence. She is an instrument of God's deliverance in a specific moment, in a specific war, under a specific covenant. The text celebrates what God did through her; it does not turn her hammer into a general ethic.

What we can imitate is her courage. She sees the moment and takes it. She does not let fear or propriety keep her from the work God has put in front of her. She is an outsider, and she becomes the point where the enemy's head is crushed.

Movement 4: The peg and the hammer

"But Jael the wife of Heber took a tent peg, and took a hammer in her hand. Then she went softly to him and drove the peg into his temple until it went down into the ground while he was lying fast asleep from weariness. So he died" (4:21).

The verse is quiet and terrible. She does not shout. She does not call for help. She goes softly. The man is snoring. The peg is sharpened, the hammer is heavy, and the tent is silent. One blow. The peg goes through his temple and into the ground. The enemy of Israel dies in his sleep with his head pinned to the floor of a woman's tent.

The song spares us nothing: "She sent her hand to the tent peg and her right hand to the workmen's mallet; she struck Sisera; she crushed his head; she shattered and pierced his temple. Between her feet he sank, he fell, he lay still; between her feet he sank, he fell; where he sank, there he fell—dead" (5:26–27).

The repetition is like a drumbeat. Sank. Fell. Lay still. Sank. Fell. Dead. The poetry is not trying to be tasteful. It is trying to make us watch. This is what the defeat of the enemy looks like. It is not a tidy lesson. It is a body on the floor of a tent.

And there is an echo here that a careful reader should hear. In the garden, God said to the serpent, "I will put enmity between you and the woman, and between your offspring and her offspring; he shall bruise your head, and you shall bruise his heel" (Genesis 3:15). Jael crushes the head of the enemy. A woman's hand drives the peg. The story is a signpost pointing to a greater promise: the day is coming when the head of the serpent will be crushed for good.

But Jael's victory is only a signpost. It is not the final victory. The enemy she kills is one man, in one tent, in one war. The serpent is still alive. The next generation will do evil again. The book of Judges will keep spiraling. Jael's peg is a real deliverance, but it is not the deliverance.

Barak arrives while the deed is still fresh. Jael comes out to meet him and says, "Come, and I will show you the man whom you are seeking" (4:22). He goes in, and there is Sisera, fallen, with the peg in his temple. The general who would not go without a woman now sees the enemy killed by a woman. The word of the LORD through Deborah is fulfilled to the letter.

There is no gloating in the text, and there should be none in the pulpit. Barak does not get the final blow, but he gets the victory. Jael does not get an army, but she gets the honor. God gets the glory. That is how the kingdom works. The people who are willing to be used, and the people who are willing to be upstaged, are the people God can trust with His victory.

The song also has a warning for the people who stayed home. "Curse Meroz, says the angel of the LORD, curse its inhabitants thoroughly, because they did not come to the help of the LORD, to the help of the LORD against the mighty" (5:23). Meroz is a town we know almost nothing about. But we know this: they had an opportunity to join the LORD's battle, and they did not. Their neutrality was not innocence. It was disobedience. The song curses them, and then it blesses Jael. The contrast is deliberate. The people who stayed safe are under a curse; the outsider who risked everything is called blessed.

"And on that day God subdued Jabin the king of Canaan before the people of Israel. And the hand of the people of Israel pressed harder and harder against Jabin the king of Canaan, until they destroyed him" (4:23–24).

The war ends. The oppressor is broken. The people who had no chariots, no army, and no hope are free. And the one who struck the final blow was not the general, not the prophetess, not the 10,000, but a foreign woman with a tent peg.

That is the kind of God we serve. He does not need the impressive. He does not need the powerful. He does not need the person with the best credentials or the biggest platform. He chooses the weak, the overlooked, the outsider, and the nobody. He takes what the world would never put on a poster and He makes it the hinge of the story.

The Song of Deborah ends with a prayer: "So may all your enemies perish, O LORD! But your friends be like the sun as he rises in his might" (5:31). The sun rises. The night is over. The enemy is dead. The land has rest.

But even that rest will not last. That is the ache beneath the song. We need a better deliverer.

Movement 5: Blessed among women

"Most blessed of women be Jael, the wife of Heber the Kenite, of tent-dwelling women most blessed" (5:24).

That is one of the highest blessings spoken over a woman in the Old Testament. It is a public, poetic, covenant blessing. And it is spoken over a woman who just killed a man with a tent peg. The Bible's idea of blessedness is not the same as ours. We think of blessing as a comfortable life, a good reputation, a family that behaves, a ministry that grows. Jael's blessing comes through a bloody act of deliverance.

And there is an echo here that the early church did not miss. When Elizabeth greets Mary, she says, "Blessed are you among women, and blessed is the fruit of your womb!" (Luke 1:42). The words are almost the same. Two women. Two unexpected callings. Two impossible deliverances.

Jael ends a war by killing an enemy. Mary bears a son who will end the war with sin and death. Jael's hand holds a hammer. Mary's hands hold a baby. Jael's tent is stained with blood. Mary's son will have His hands and feet pierced.

The contrast is the gospel. Jael was called blessed for driving a nail into the enemy. Jesus was called blessed for taking the nails that were meant for us. Jael's peg went down into the ground and pinned a dead man. Jesus' cross went into the ground and came out empty.

And Mary's song makes the same reversal plain. "He has shown strength with his arm; he has scattered the proud in the thoughts of their hearts; he has brought down the mighty from their thrones and exalted those of humble estate" (Luke 1:51–52). That is the pattern of Judges 4 and Judges 5. The mighty are brought down. The humble are lifted up. The general runs; the woman is blessed. The world's pyramid is turned upside down.

But Mary's son does not defeat the enemy the way Jael did. He does not take a hammer. He takes a cross. He does not crush the head of His enemy; He lets His enemies crush Him, and then He rises. The cross looks like defeat. The tomb looks like the end. But on the third day, the stone is rolled away, and the true deliverance is finished.

That is the mystery at the heart of the gospel. The judgment of God against sin is real, and it fell on Jesus. The victory of God over the enemy is real, and it was won by Jesus. The tent peg shows us that evil must be judged. The cross shows us how God judged it without destroying us. The resurrection shows us that the judgment is over and the war is won.

We are not Israel in this story. We are Sisera. We are the ones who have run from God, broken His law, and made peace with His enemies. We are the ones who deserve the judgment. And that is why the cross is such good news. The judgment that should have fallen on us fell on the Son of God. He took the nails. He took the spear. He took the curse. And He did it for His enemies.

"And you, who were dead in your trespasses and the uncircumcision of your flesh, God made alive together with him, having forgiven us all our trespasses, by canceling the record of debt that stood against us with its legal demands. This he set aside, nailing it to the cross. He disarmed the rulers and authorities and put them to open shame, by triumphing over them in him" (Colossians 2:13–15).

Nailed to the cross. The record of debt. The accusations. The powers. All of it nailed. Not because we were strong. Not because we were faithful. Because He is. The enemy thought he had won. He watched the Son of God die. And on the third day, the tomb was empty. The serpent's head was crushed.

The prophetess said the honor would go to a woman. The woman took a peg. The greater woman bore a son. And the son took the nails. That is the long, strange, gracious line of redemption. God wins through the unlikely, and He wins completely.

So what do we do with this story? We do not pick up a hammer and look for enemies. We pick up our cross and follow the one who took the nails. We stop hiding in the tent. We stop guarding the door. We come out into the light of the risen sun.

Application: What do you do with the tent peg?

1. Do not wait for the perfect moment

Jael acted in the narrow window between Sisera's collapse and Barak's arrival. It was not a convenient moment. She did not have a plan that had been approved by the elders. She had a sleeping enemy and a tool in her hand, and she used the moment God gave her.

Most of us are waiting for a better moment. We will speak up when we have more courage. We will serve when the schedule clears. We will forgive when the other person apologizes. We will follow Christ when we have cleaned up our lives. But the moment God gives is usually the one we have right now, with the resources and the weaknesses we have right now.

Obedience is often an interruption. It comes in the middle of dinner, in the middle of a workday, in the middle of a sleepless night. The question is not whether you are ready. The question is whether you will move when the moment comes. Jael did not have a five-year plan. She had a sleeping enemy and a sharp piece of wood. She moved. And God used it to end a war.

2. Do not mistake peace for passivity

Heber's house had peace with Jabin. It was a comfortable arrangement. They had their tents, their land, their safety, and their treaty. But their peace was built on the oppression of God's people. Jael was willing to break that peace because she saw what it was.

The church can make the same mistake. We can confuse being comfortable with being faithful. We can call it "peace" when we mean "we do not want the conflict that obedience would bring." We can keep our heads down, keep our mouths shut, and keep our reputation intact while the enemy keeps the valley.

The peace of God is not the absence of conflict. It is the presence of God's justice and mercy. Sometimes it requires us to speak when it is costly. Sometimes it requires us to act when it is inconvenient. Sometimes it requires us to leave the safety of the tent and stand in the open.

3. Use what is in your hand

Jael did not have a sword. She did not have an army. She did not have a chariot. She had a tent peg and a hammer. Those were the tools of her daily work. God used them to end a war.

God has always worked this way. He used a shepherd's staff in Moses' hand. He used a sling and a stone in David's hand. He used a widow's jar of oil, a boy's loaves and fish, a handkerchief in Paul's hand. He used a towel and a basin in the hands of His Son.

What is in your hand? It might look ordinary. It might be your home, your work, your skills, your money, your story, your time. The question is not whether it is impressive. The question is whether you will offer it to the God who makes it enough.

4. Give the victory to God

The song says the stars fought and the river swept the enemy away. It says the LORD routed Sisera. Jael was brave, but she was not the savior. She was the instrument. The victory was the LORD's.

We need to hear that in a culture that celebrates the hero. We want the story to be about us. We want our name on the trophy. We want the platform, the applause, the credit. But the

gospel will not allow it. The victory belongs to God. He is the one who breaks the enemy. He is the one who raises the dead. He is the one who gets the glory.

That is not bad news. It is freedom. If the victory is God's, then I do not have to save anyone. I do not have to be the hero. I do not have to carry the weight of the world. I can be the woman with the peg, the man with the sling, the nobody with the towel. I can do my part and leave the outcome to Him.

And I can stop comparing my part to someone else's. Jael did not have Barak's army. Barak did not have Jael's tent. Deborah did not have either, but she had the word of the LORD. The body of Christ is not a competition for the spotlight; it is a body, with different members, different gifts, and one Lord. The hand cannot say to the foot, "I do not need you." The woman with the peg cannot say to the general, "I do not need you." We need each other, and we all need the victory that only God can give.

The invitation

There are three kinds of people in this story, and all three are in this room.

There is a Sisera: you have been running from God, from your past, from the thing you did. You thought you had found a safe tent. You thought you could hide. But the door you are standing in front of is not the door you think it is. The judgment of God is real. You cannot talk your way out of it, and you cannot sleep it off. You need a deliverer.

There is a Barak: you believe the promise, but you are afraid to go without a sign. You have been waiting for someone else to go first. You have been waiting for the perfect moment, the perfect church, the perfect preacher, the perfect version of yourself. The LORD is still saying, "Does not the LORD go out before you?" You can move.

There is a Jael: you have been overlooked, underestimated, and told that you do not have a place in the story. You have a peg and a hammer. You have a home, a skill, a story, and a God who chooses the weak things of the world to shame the strong. Your life can be the place where the enemy's head is crushed.

The invitation is not "be like Jael." The invitation is "come to the one who took the nail." Jesus is the greater deliverer. He did not kill His enemies; He died for them. He did not save Himself; He saved us. He went into the ground, and on the third day He rose. The war is over. The enemy is defeated. The door is open.

Come to Him. Not because you are strong. Not because you are clean. Not because you have a plan. Come because He is faithful. Come because He is the one who ends the war.

Response

Take a moment in silence. Put the story down for a second and let it ask you a question.

Which person are you in the story?

Are you running? Are you hiding in a tent you thought was safe? Are you covered in the shame of something you cannot fix? Then hear this: the judgment of God fell on Jesus, and the door is open. You do not have to keep running.

Are you waiting? Are you dragging your feet when God has already given you the word? Then hear this: the LORD goes before you. You do not need a bigger sign. You need the courage to move.

Are you overlooked? Are you the outsider at the table, the woman in the background, the person everyone counts out? Then hear this: God has a habit of choosing the unlikely. He used a woman in a tent to end a war. He can use you.

Now read Colossians 2:13–15 again. Say it slowly. "The record of debt that stood against us" has been canceled. It was nailed to the cross. The rulers and authorities have been disarmed. The enemy has been put to shame. You are not saved by your hammer. You are saved by His nails.

If you are in Christ, the war is over. You are not fighting for victory; you are fighting from victory. You are not earning peace; you are living in peace. You are not trying to be blessed; you are already blessed in the Beloved.

Pray with me:

"Lord Jesus, we are Sisera, Barak, and Jael all at once. We have run from you, we have hesitated to obey you, and we have tried to carry the victory ourselves. Forgive us. We come to the cross. We trust the nails that were meant for us. We receive the peace that you bought with your blood. Make us brave in the small moments, faithful with the tools in our hands, and humble enough to give you the glory. In your name, amen."

If you are not yet a Christian, the invitation is open. You do not have to clean up first. You do not have to understand everything. You do not have to be a hero. You need a Savior. Come to Him.

If you have been hurt by violence, abuse, or war, this story may be hard to hear. Please do not hear this sermon as a command to take vengeance. The Bible says, "Vengeance is mine, I will repay" (Romans 12:19). The church is meant to be a place where the wounded can find safety, not a place where they are told to pick up a hammer. If you need help, please speak to a pastor, a counselor, or a trusted friend this week.

Closing

The tent peg ended a war.

The nails ended the enmity.

The sun has risen. The enemy is defeated. The door is open.

Go in peace, and live like people whose war is over.

Evidence note for the preacher

The two accounts. Judges 4 is prose; Judges 5 is a song. They tell the same story with different emphases, and they are complementary rather than contradictory. The song is one of the oldest passages in the Hebrew Bible, and it preserves vivid details (the stars, the torrent Kishon, the milk in a lordly bowl, the mother of Sisera at the window) that the prose account does not emphasize. Preach the passage in its canonical context, and use the song to illuminate the narrative.

The historical setting. Hazor is a large tell in Upper Galilee and was one of the most important cities in the ancient world. The name Jabin may be a dynastic title rather than a personal name. Harosheth-hagoyim is not confidently identified; proposed sites are in the Kishon area. Do not base the sermon on a precise archaeological identification of every site. The essential historical claims are the reality of the oppression, the iron chariots, the Kishon valley, and the rout described.

The iron chariots. Nine hundred chariots would have been a massive force. Chariots were the high-tech weapon of the period, and iron fittings made them formidable. The Kishon valley's clay soil and flash flooding are a plausible mechanism for the rout, but the text attributes the victory to the LORD, not to weather or tactics. The song's imagery of the stars and the torrent is poetry, not a meteorological report.

The Kenites. The Kenites were associated with Hobab, Moses' father-in-law (Judges 1:16; 4:11). Heber had separated from the main group and pitched his tent by Kedesh, and there was peace between his house and Jabin (4:11, 17). Jael's act therefore violates a treaty and the ancient code of hospitality. The text celebrates her as God's instrument of judgment, not as an example of private vengeance. Be honest about the moral tension; do not flatten it into a simple hero story.

The violence. Do not glamorize the killing. The sermon should name the horror of the act and locate it within the larger story of God's judgment and deliverance. Jael is not a model for personal revenge, and the sermon should say so. Provide a pastoral note for anyone who has experienced violence or abuse. The cross is the place where the judgment of God and the mercy of God meet; that is the ultimate answer to the violence of this fallen world.

"Most blessed of women." The blessing in Judges 5:24 is a superlative within the song. The echo in Luke 1:42 is a canonical resonance, not a direct prediction. Preach it as a pattern: God chooses the unlikely, and the greater deliverance comes through Mary's son. Do not claim that Mary is the literal fulfillment of Judges 5:24.

Genesis 3:15. The language of crushing the enemy's head is a deliberate echo of the first promise. The New Testament identifies Jesus as the one who defeats the serpent (Romans 16:20; Colossians 2:15; 1 John 3:8). Keep the typology modest: Jael is a signpost, not an allegory. The tent peg is not a direct prophecy of the nails; the connection is the pattern of God defeating evil through an unexpected deliverer.

Barak. Hebrews 11:32 names Barak among the faithful. His request for Deborah to go with him is not unbelief in the absolute sense; it is a weak faith that still obeys. Preach him with sympathy, not contempt. The contrast between Barak and Jael is not a contrast between a bad man and a good woman; it is a contrast between human honor and God's surprising grace.

Deborah. Deborah is a prophetess and judge, and the song calls her "a mother in Israel" (5:7). Celebrate God's choice of a woman to lead His people. Do not turn the passage into a culture-war sermon; the point is God's deliverance through the unlikely, not a template for every office in the church.

The ending. The song ends with the mother of Sisera looking out the window, waiting for a son who will never return (5:28–30), and with the prayer, "So may all your enemies perish, O LORD!" (5:31). Do not skip the pathos. War is not a game. The triumph of God's justice is real,

but it is also sobering. Preach the ending with fear and trembling, and let it point to the day when the nations will beat their swords into plowshares and the Prince of Peace will reign.

Translation note. "Most blessed of women" in Judges 5:24 is a poetic superlative. "Blessed are you among women" in Luke 1:42 is a distinct New Testament greeting. The English wording is close; the theological connection is canonical, not linguistic. Be careful not to overclaim a word-for-word fulfillment.

Scripture quotations are ESV.